

on building an interactive television set from scratch. However, it wasn't till 1966, when Baer was working as the Chief Engineer for Equipment Design for the defense contractor Sanders Associates, that he jotted down a description for a "game box" that would allow for games to be played and visualised on a TV screen.

The idea was so impressive that Baer was granted \$2,500 and two engineers, Bill Rusch and Bill Harrison, to fund creation of prototypes. Over the next two years, the three churned out multiple prototypes of Baer's idea till they came up with the "Brown Box", that allowed for multiplayer gaming.

Baer approached multiple companies and TV manufacturers to mass produce his Brown Box, till Magnavox, an American TV manufacturer, picked up his idea in 1971. After modifying certain features like the usage of plug-in circuits to change games, and replacing color graphics with color overlays to reduce manufacturing costs, Magnavox released the Magnavox Odyssey.

Compared to other technology at the time, the Odyssey seemed like a truly futuristic device, despite its obvious shortcomings. The master control unit was a white, rectangular unit, powered by a battery and complete with a front loading game card slot. There were two player control units that allowed a maximum of two players at a time. The units were basic and did not feature an ergonomic or user friendly design.

In stark contrast with units produced later, the Odyssey featured the use of transparent screen overlays, which were plastic sheets that could be stuck to the screen and used as backgrounds, as required by some games.



Ralph Baer